



Ten Essentials Checklist

Pierce County 4x4 Search & Rescue | piercecounty4x4sar.org

EMERGENCY

CALL 911

THE TEN ESSENTIAL SYSTEMS -- CARRY ALL 10, EVERY TRIP

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|----|--------------------------|--|
| 1 | Navigation | Topo map + compass + GPS/phone with offline maps. Know how to use them all. |
| 2 | Headlamp | LED headlamp + extra batteries. Test before every trip. Hands-free light. |
| 3 | Sun Protection | SPF 30+ sunscreen, UV sunglasses, hat, lip balm with SPF. Reapply every 2 hrs. |
| 4 | First Aid Kit | Bandages, gauze, tape, pain meds, blister care, personal meds. Check dates. |
| 5 | Knife + Repair | Multi-tool, duct tape (3+ ft), cord/paracord (50 ft), zip ties, safety pins. |
| 6 | Fire Starting | Waterproof matches AND lighter + fire starter. Both -- redundancy matters. |
| 7 | Emergency Shelter | Bivy, space blanket, or ultralight tarp. Practice setup at home first. |
| 8 | Extra Food | 1+ extra day's worth. Bars, nuts, jerky, peanut butter. No cooking required. |
| 9 | Extra Water | 1L+ extra + purification (filter, tablets, or UV). Pre-hydrate before hike. |
| 10 | Extra Clothing | Insulating layer, rain jacket + pants, warm hat, gloves. NO COTTON. |

FIELD TIPS

- ☐ **Total weight:** A complete kit weighs only 3-5 lbs. There is no excuse to skip it.
- ☐ **Cotton kills:** Loses ALL insulation when wet. Wool or synthetic materials only.
- ☐ **Cold batteries:** Lose 20-40% capacity in cold. Keep phone and headlamp in inside pockets.
- ☐ **Pre-hydrate:** Drink 16 oz in the hour before you start. Dark urine = already dehydrated.
- ☐ **Keep it packed:** Dedicated bag, always ready to grab. Check expiration dates each season.

MOST RESCUES INVOLVE DAY HIKERS

The majority of people we rescue planned to be out for 'just a few hours.' Afternoon weather, a wrong turn, or a minor injury can turn a short hike into an overnight. Always pack as if you might spend the night out. Pierce County spans sea level to 14,411 ft (Mt. Rainier) -- prepare for the highest point on your route.